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Vincent Pelote

Vincent Pelote is the Director of Operations at the Institute for Jazz Studies at Rutgers University. His early interest in jazz guitar led to a dual career as a jazz historian and music librarian.

Vincent was interviewed in Orlando, Florida on February 25, 2017 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Orlando at the MLA conference, and I'm very happy to have Vincent Pelote with me today, Director of Operations at the Institute of Jazz Studies at Rutgers. Welcome.

VP: Thank you, Monk.

MR: You've been perking my ears up the last couple of days when I hear you talking to other people. And I can sense your passion for jazz and I'm going to start out with an easy question.

VP: Thank you. I like easy questions.

MR: How about defining swing for us?

VP: [Laughs] Oh come on man. Please tell me you are joking.

MR: No. I'm not. But it did occur to me that with the big band the last couple of nights, playing the tunes from that era, the 30s and stuff, that the solid rhythm underneath this [scats] those horn parts are so syncopated and that the wonderful, smooth sort of tension it creates is just astounding.

VP: Yeah, exactly. And I like the fact that if you listen to those, the little figures that Fletcher Henderson or Horace Henderson did as backgrounds to the soloists, I think they are wonderful by themselves, just listening to those background figures. They're very nice.

MR: And they're really tricky to play.

VP: Yes. Exactly.

MR: It made me appreciate the arrangers and the cats that played those things.

VP: Sure.

MR: Because sometimes you read about the fact that maybe they all weren't great readers, but they, boy, they did that stuff so well.

VP: Well and they also had section rehearsals I'm sure they sat down and the sections just rehearsed. I mean certainly that happened in Lunceford's band a lot where the sections would just rehearse their parts and then when they came together, boom, they're ready to roll. So exactly. They wanted to make sure they got it right and made it sound good.

MR: Yeah. There was a — I was doing a little poking around about you.

VP: Uh oh.

MR: It was all good.

VP: Well good.

MR: There was a magazine, you wrote, maybe it was a column, answers to your jazz history questions.

VP: Oh no. *Jazz Magazine* out of Northport, New York. "Fragments" was the column.

MR: Did you get — what kind of questions did people ask you?

VP: All right. I was very young at the time, okay? In fact Chris White was the director at the time, so we are talking '74, '75. I was still in college, wet behind the ears just really sort of getting into the whole jazz thing. And the kind of questions that were sent were sort of like — I guess you call them trivia questions now you know. What recording did Rahsaan Roland Kirk play a sarrusophone on or some things like that. Also I will confess now that the magazine is defunct that some of those questions were plants. I asked my brother to ask me a question and I would put it in, or I would ask a friend to send me a question or ask me a question and I would include it. Because I didn't want to just make up something. I figured so at least I could say legitimately that somebody asked me this, they at least sent it in. Because we had to have a column and sometimes nothing was coming in. We weren't getting any people writing anything in. And I will admit there was one question that I wish to this day I could do over again, the answer. It was about Fletcher Henderson versus Benny Goodman. You know, why was Goodman successful playing the exact same arrangements that Fletcher Henderson played. And I was sort of into my — how can I put this — I was sort of into my black nationalist bag at that time, which believe me I'm nowhere a black nationalist in any way, shape or form, but at that time I was sort of sniffing around in that area. And of course I launched into this whole tirade about how well yes, the black musicians were treated like crap and Fletcher, his music was twenty times better than Benny Goodman's, but because he was black — of course I didn't know or was aware until much, much later was that Henderson was paid very well for those arrangements, he was paid probably better than most arrangers were getting at that time, and Goodman loved him. Goodman considered him like a second father, really. And really took him in when he disbanded his band in '34 and put him basically on the payroll and just had him turn out charts for him. A lot of them he didn't even use, he just put them in the library and never got back to performing them or recording them, but he gave the guy a steady gig. And then when their band disbanded later, when Fletcher re-formed and then disbanded later, Goodman took him back in the organization and that's how he ends up on those Charlie Christian-Goodman things as the pianist, even though he had a perfectly good pianist in the band, Jess Stacy, who he didn't use on any of those recordings. He gave them to Fletcher Henderson instead. I love the guy but his piano playing at that point was really very old fashioned, out of step.

MR: He wasn't that effective a leader.

VP: No. He wasn't. Not at all. No. He just wasn't. They talk about that accident that happened, the car accident, which after that he seemed very aloof and not really interested much in promoting the band very much. But even before that I kind of wonder how much of a leader he really was. I mean he didn't have an Irving Mills like Ellington had or Cab Calloway, somebody like that. I mean Hammond sort of came in at some point and sort of tried to take the band, do stuff with the band and stuff, and get them recording sessions and I think did some English Columbia and things like that. But there was no person pushing the Henderson band like Mills and those cats were doing, and Glaser was doing for Armstrong. And I think that was the problem with that band you know. Fletcher just wasn't a very good businessman. He just wasn't.

MR: Well a question — I don't know if I would have had it back then — but I've never really been clear about Benny Goodman's role with this integration thing and how that happened. And you had said something to me yesterday about it. And Helen Dance had talked about her role in that. But what's your take on exactly how it happened.

VP: Well my take on it is sort of what I've gotten from reading various books and articles. So I mean I wasn't there so I can't say I have any firsthand knowledge, but I just got the impression that, you know, he wanted these two musicians in his organization. He wanted Wilson and he wanted Hampton. But he was smart enough to know that if he put them in the full big band it was going to cause problems. Not that they weren't going to cause problems anyway having them as a sideshow, but I think it caused less problems because they weren't sitting in the band with the rest of the musicians and he could bring them out as a side act and then put them away when they were finished and that was fine. It seemed to be acceptable I guess, more so than if they were actually sitting in the band, in the section. I don't know where Hampton would have sat because really there's no place for a vibe in those arrangements, but certainly, I mean he carried two pianists. He had Stacy and he had Wilson. And I guess if he'd had his druthers he probably would have had Wilson on piano for the whole thing. But I'm just talking. I don't really know for sure. But that's how I kind of saw it. Like he wanted what he wanted but he did it in a smart way, I think better than what Artie Shaw did by sticking Eldridge in there and Cooper later with Eldridge sitting there in the section and the shit they had to put up with, I'm sorry, the crap they had to put up with. Yeah.

MR: Well there sure are a lot of Benny Goodman stories.

VP: Oh God I've heard them, tons of them. And I can't figure it out, why he was like he was. I always tell people I think Terry Gibbs summed it up perfectly when he said, "The man was crazy. The man was meshuga."

MR: I bet today there would be a designated psychological definition for what he was about.

VP: Yeah. I'll tell you who has probably very good insight, and you should talk to him if you haven't already, is Loren Schoenberg at the Jazz Museum in Harlem. Because he worked with Benny for a number of years. And he got the full treatment, everything from praise to damnation, he got the whole thing. And Benny took his band away from him eventually. He took off his gloves man.

MR: Touché. You know Joe Wilder, he went on that tour to Russia.

VP: Oh.

MR: Joe would not even say Benny's name.

VP: Yeah.

MR: That clarinet player was all he would say. Just wow. For Joe Wilder, who was like a gentle man.

VP: A nice man. I knew him. I used to meet him in New York with Ed Berger, we used to go see him play, and he would come and talk to me at the table. Always asked me about my brother. I thought it was so funny, he met my brother maybe twice and every time he saw me he asked me, "How's your brother doing." And I was so touched by that. And another musician who wouldn't mention Benny because he had a run-in with Benny Goodman was George Duvivier. Like also I met him, and what he would do is he would always call Benny Carter Ben. He wouldn't call him Benny. Because of the connection with Benny Goodman.

MR: Wow. You know what I loved about Joe and I noticed it with Milt Hinton and other fellows of that generation is they were such gentlemen, they were so nice, but at the same time if you disrespected them, like in a business fashion or — I witnessed this like a couple of times. Someone suggesting that they weren't living up to their obligations. They took the heat and they were wait a minute, don't besmirch my professionalism. And it was really good to witness that. You can be a nice guy and also stand up for your —

VP: I saw it with Benny Carter also. He played a club in New York, Carlos #1 I guess it was. It was a club that was on Sixth Avenue. And he insisted on being paid in cash. And the guy said he would, the owner of the club said he would. And the guy was going to go back on that after Benny had played. And Benny insisted, "You give me my cash, this is what we agreed on — you don't give me my cash you know —." I don't know what the consequences would have been but it was quite obvious that he was making Benny very angry. And you don't get Benny Carter angry. That's a side of Benny you don't want to see.

MR: No kidding.

VP: Yeah. All that stuff about him being a gentleman and all that stuff. Yeah, he is, but don't rile him. Don't mess with him. Really. He got his cash. Believe me. At the end of the night he got his cash.

MR: So I saw a video of you, I guess it was taken at the Association of Recorded Sound Collections.

VP: Oh God.

MR: And you were saying different people collect different things, and we all have our passions.

VP: Sure.

MR: So what was your passion as a young man.

VP: My passion as a young man was always, like most kids I listened to the popular music of the day, I had my little transistor radio. Remember those little 9-volt transistor radios you used to put to your ear? Or you had the one earphone that stuck in. Yeah. So I had that and I generally listened to the black stations on the other end of the dial, you know, WWRL and I liked Motown and all that. But then my uncle, Lester Pelote, was a professional jazz guitarist in New York. He never really broke out of the local scene and eventually became a cab driver and that was pretty much it. But he used to come to the house a lot, in Jersey City, and visit his brother, my father. And I got interested in guitar at that point. And my father, who wasn't a musician but who liked jazz and had really two jazz albums that he played consistently, especially when he was a little drunk, he played the Wes Montgomery Trio on the Riverside label, the first album that Wes ever made, and an album that Al Casey, they called "Buck Jumpin' on Swingville Prestige. And he played those two records over and over and over again to the point where my sisters were complaining about it — stop it, dad. But you know I saw him listening to them and to me, as a budding guitarist, because I was interested in playing guitar because of my uncle so I was fussing around with it, I was listening to this and I said yea, I like Wes. Al Casey is more approachable. I can copy him better. Because it was mostly single note stuff and it was a simpler style, a simpler single string style, because he goes back to the 30s, and Wes was more of a post-bop guitarist, even though he started out playing Charlie Christian solos. And so his stuff was hard. And then the octave thing which was completely out of my — I didn't know what the hell was even going on with that. And of course soloing in chords, using block chords was completely like — you know. So I fell in love with the Al Casey album first. But then I started listening to more and more Wes and he became my hero. And so my passion became that, and also again, I have to point to my sister's collection. She had the record "Hello Dolly" in her 45 collection. Now I know it was a big hit in '64, it knocked The Beatles off the chart that year, but I didn't really dig the record until 1966, '67, '66. And I started playing it and listening to it and I liked it. I liked the other side better by the way, "A Lot of Living to do" was the other side of that record, the 45. But you know, I listened to it, and I knew about Armstrong, I knew he was supposed to be this great musician but by '66, '67, '68, '67, he was just

appearing on shows and he had the handkerchief and he didn't play much trumpet at that point and I was just kind of wondering what's so great about this guy. I mean everybody thinks he's so wonderful. Because "Hello Dolly" was nice but I didn't see it as anything that really knocked me out. So I went to the local library in Jersey City, the Fine Arts Library, and I pulled out an album that had an old track of Armstrong playing "Big Butter and Egg Man From the West" with the Hot Five. And I listened to it and don't ask me why, but as a kid I must have been 14 or 13, when he took that solo at the end of that record, after the vocal, I just perked. I just like wow, now I get it. I could see why this was great. Because I don't think anybody else was playing like that. And I didn't know that for a fact, because I wasn't immersed in that time period of music, but something about it just sounded so modern and different than anything that preceded it. And the settings just seemed weird, that this archaic sounding recording had this great stuff coming out of it. And so I just started trying to find as much jazz from that time period as I could. And so, back to the Five Corners Library, pulling out more records, because you could take LPs out and you could take them home and play them and bring them back. And I had an old Wallensak open reel tape recorder, and I used to record the records after I got them and then I just played the Wallensak tapes back over and over and over again. And so my passion really became early jazz, circa 1920s, 30s, and up to the bop era. A little later I started getting into bop. But that's how I did it. I went back to the beginning and I worked my way up to the modern jazz eventually. And you know I loved Bird when I finally heard Bird, and I didn't find it all that radical when I heard him because I guess I'd been listening to stuff that, you know, post-bop, that was sort of in your head anyway. So I used to say I don't know how swing people were so crazy, it sounded perfectly logical to me, what he was doing. But then I read that they weren't happy with the bop stuff. They thought it was weird, and Chinese music Dizzy Gillespie called it, and all that stuff. But I didn't get it. It sounded fine to me. But anyway, that was my passion. My passion was —

MR: So you weren't a moldy fig.

VP: No I wasn't a moldy fig at all. I loved bop and beyond.

MR: It's very curious how one thing leads to another, sometimes backwards.

VP: Yeah.

MR: I made the mistake of buying "Om" by John Coltrane when someone told me about John Coltrane. And it wasn't the right record to get.

VP: No.

MR: And so it took me some time to even put another Coltrane record on.

VP: Sure. Yep.

MR: And so do you pursue this in higher education? How did this passion delve into a career?

VP: Okay, when I went to college — oh I played guitar all throughout high school, pretty much on my own. I mean I am a self-taught guitar player. I didn't take lessons. And I just listened a lot, I got the Mel Bay books for guitar and I went through the whole chord system so I could have a system. I didn't want just a bunch of chords, I wanted a system so that I could play whatever was put in front of me by just using this system. So I did that. Of course I've since learned I was playing these crazy chords, didn't have to play with any — that's another story. And I fell in love with the whole concept of playing in a rhythm section and just playing chords. To me that was the greatest thing in the world, that somebody would devote themselves to just doing that. Eddie Condon was my hero. I loved Eddie Condon for just sitting there and doing that, and Freddie Green of course. But there were other rhythm guitars. Everybody talks about Freddie Green, but there's other ways to play rhythm guitar. His is not the only way. Marty Grosz makes that quite clear today, that there are other types of rhythm guitar that you can play. I mean Dick McDonough was that wonderful rhythm guitarist, as were, I can just rattle off a bunch of names. Clayton "Sunshine" Duerr, who played with Louie Prima and, or Mezz Mezzrow. He played with Mezz Mezzrow and his orchestra. So there's a whole bunch of guys like that that were just great rhythm guitar players, without necessarily sounding like Freddie Green. So that became my passion. And so I went to college to be basically, I went to be a writer originally but I went on the wrong day. So there was no orientation day, so there was nobody from the English department there, but there was a guy from the music department, so I went over to him. His name was Chester Fanning Smith. He was a classical pianist.

MR: And this was at what school?

VP: This was Rutgers University in Newark. Yeah. So I went over there because I got accepted to Rutgers. So I figured okay fine, this is good, I will go to Rutgers and be an English major. But anyway he talked to me and he said, "You know there's a lot of things you could do with a music degree." And he was trying to talk to me about becoming part of the department. And he gave me this sheet of paper that had all the different types of jobs you could get if you got a music degree. And I was floored. Because I figured the only thing you could do with music is play, and I didn't think I was good enough to be a performer. And so I looked at it and said, "Hey, not bad." So I signed up to be a music major. And I told him, I said, "I really don't know that much about classical music but I love jazz. I mean if you guys don't mind me being a jazz guy, okay." And he was like, "Sure, no problem, come on in." You know. So I did it and I don't know, all through the four years that I was there, four and a half years, I was in this constant fight where, you know, they were doing the classical thing. In fact I remember for my audition to be in, I guess the choir, they wanted you to sing a song, and so they were all singing these

classical things. I chose "Moonlight Serenade." That was my audition piece. Because I knew —

MR: Not "Caro Mio Ben" right?

VP: I taught this poor young lady to play piano behind me on this thing and I was terrible. I mean I am not a singer. I am horrible. And she put up with that. And today, we still talk about it today, sitting in the practice room, and she had to coach me into doing this. And another thing I did with the jazz thing is in the orchestration class we were given a little piece of music to orchestrate, and while they're all doing classical things, I orchestrated a Duke Ellington thing. So every chance I got I tried to work that in, into my education, and it just never left me. It just stuck. So I settled on being a music ed teacher, because I figured all right, I would get out, I would probably get a stage band or a jazz band, a high school level thing, and I could do that. Because I didn't want to be a vocal teacher. I didn't want to do the vocal choir thing. I wanted to do a band thing. So I figured that's going to be my thing. I was going to just be that. And maybe that's where I'd be today if Ed Berger hadn't called me and said, "Vinny, there's a job at the Institute. We have a two year grant to catalogue sound recordings, and we need someone who knows something about jazz. We'll teach you how to catalogue, but we just need the jazz expertise and I know you have it. Do you want to leave teaching and do this for two years." I said, "Yes, take me away." Because I'd been substitute teaching and it was like horrible, the kids were terrible, I couldn't stand it anymore And I said, "I'll take it. I'll take it for two years and we'll see what happens." So I did. And it was the first time that anybody had done a catalogue project of that nature for jazz music on a national database. And that was OCLC at the time. That was the only national database that was really out there. So that's how I got started. That's really where the whole thing started. And I just never left. Because once the grant was out they applied for another one to do LPs. First it was 78s, then it was LPs, so I did that. And then after that we just sort of killed the whole thing and they realized, you know, Vinny knows more than just how to catalog sound recordings. He knows a lot about jazz. So they kept me on and just kept moving me from one thing to another.

MR: Yeah. You were learning on the job.

VP: Yeah exactly. And eventually I got a degree. I went down to New Brunswick's library school and I got my degree in library science. And I was able to get the job that the librarian there had, before me. And in fact it was her — she in fact told me, "You should get the degree because I'm going to retire soon and you'll probably be the perfect replacement, if you get your degree." So I did. And I don't recommend people get a degree just for one job. Because if I didn't get that job I didn't know what I would have done. Because I didn't want to do anything else. I didn't want to be a music librarian in

some other institution. I wanted to be in the Institute of Jazz Studies. I mean if I didn't get that job I don't know what I would have done. But that's weird. It just worked out. But it was a gamble. It was a big gamble.

MR: Well I can attest that it's a pretty cool place.

VP: It's wonderful. It's always been.

MR: What is the coolest thing in the collection, as far as you're concerned?

VP: As far as I'm concerned, oh God. There's just so many things. I mean but I guess I'd have to say the coolest thing is Lester Young's tenor saxophone.

MR: That's what I would have said. Because I was only there the one time but, oh look —

VP: Yeah. There's something magical about it. And I just look at it and I can see him holding it, that weird way he held the sax and everything, and those beautiful sounds coming out of that horn man. And I'm not even a horn player man, but I appreciate Prez man.

MR: I love that moment that they captured on "The Sound of Jazz" with Lester and Billie.

VP: And Billie. The face on her when he's playing that solo. I mean she's just like —

MR: Just about a month ago I finally sat down and tried to write out his solo.

VP: Oh cool.

MR: You know, and compared to doing some transcriptions it's not that hard. But it's so perfect.

VP: Yeah. It's just amazing. I remember you showed the film when you asked somebody what do they think about when they improvise – I think it was Bill Charlap. And you know, his answer was actually perfect. I mean I guess you really don't sit down thinking all right I'm going to go from a C7 now to, I've got to make the third go here. Because how can you? You can't. Well you're an improviser. You know. It's just so ingrained in you, it's like breathing I guess. And I guess that was Prez man. Beautiful music just came out of that horn, man. That's great stuff. The other cool thing I would say, and this is because I am a guitarist, we have one of Eddie Condon's guitars. It's a four-string tenor guitar. And I just think that's great, because I would have loved to have been in there when he was playing that thing.

MR: I love reading about those guys. Like in Bill Crow's book, you know.

VP: He's got great stories.

MR: It's the jazz life. And sometimes you wonder – well that's another subject, about then and now. I cracked up at the rehearsal, I think it was last night, because one guy was going to say, he was saying, "we're going to take a donation to collect a little money for some of the ringers." So he says, "we're taking a donation" and someone said, "do you take 78s?" I said, "How perfect is that?" What to do with the 78s.

VP: Oh God we get that almost every day. So, but it's, "Oh my father just died," or, you know, "he had a collection of 78s." Mostly it's LPs that they want to give us. And you

know, and they're so convinced these are the most greatest most unique collection in the world, and, "Oh it's got lots of Louis Armstrong and Duke Ellington and Count Basie." And I hate to always tell them, "Yeah, these are probably kind of common LPs. We probably have every one of them that he had in his collection too, and we just can't take them because we have no space." The space is not there.

MR: Has anybody ever used them?

VP: Yes. People do come in and use it. And I was shocked one day when somebody came in, just one of the community people in the Newark community – because we're open to everybody, we're not just open to students, it's open to everybody – he came in and he wanted to hear a Miles Davis recording. But he said, "I don't want to hear the CD, I want to hear the LP." And so I did a double take and said, "You sure? I mean it's the same record." "No, no, no" he said, "I want to hear the LP. The LP sounds different." So I got him the LP and he was happy as a clam. But that's so rare, really, that somebody is that insistent on listening to an LP. A lot of times we give people LPs because there are no CD equivalents. And that's still, unfortunately, the truth. And I hate to hear about the impending death of the CD because not everything has been switched over. There are still LPs that you'll never see on CDs. And that's a shame, if CDs are going to die.

MR: Oh right. They're not going to make them anymore.

VP: And downloading? I'm sorry. Maybe it's just what pains me is the old fogy that I am, I do not like downloading. I just don't. I don't.

MR: I agree.

VP: I don't care for it at all.

MR: And I got a good deal of my jazz education from reading liner notes.

VP: Yes, yes.

MR: You know you're in the record store and you're reading and you learn who writes, who do you agree with, so I'm going to buy this because this person says this thing about it.

VP: Yep. One of the first things I told Dan Morgenstern when I knew he was the Institute of Jazz Studies Director was, you know how many records I've bought strictly on the fact that you said it was a great record? And he gets all sheepish and everything.

MR: Yeah, I was just going to say, "Well I hope you liked them."

VP: I said, "Dan, you're the man." You know.

MR: Who are the most, I don't know, short list of the most interesting people you've met doing your work?

VP: Well I didn't meet him, but I did some work for him, long distance work for him. I did some work on Leonard Feather's book, *Earwitness to an Era."* I think it was his last book. And he couldn't come out to the Institute so he sort of hired me to do some digging and stuff. And he paid me nicely, gave me check and everything. And I knew of him, I

knew about him from reading and all of that and I knew all of the great things he did in terms of promoting the music and everything. And so I was very happy and proud to work for Leonard Feather. As far as meeting other people, Gunther Schuller, I met Gunther Schuller who I thought was one of the nicest people ever. He was doing some work on his book about the Swing Era. He pulled out about a ton of LPs and sat down and listened to these things over and over and over again, which was great. And I really enjoyed him. And believe it or not I met him at the Institute, Bennett Lester Carter. Benny Carter. He came over, well, the Ed Berger connection. Ed's father wrote the definitive biography of Benny Carter, and Ed wrote the discography. It was a two-volume thing. The first volume was the history of Benny, the biography. The discography was the second volume. And Ed did that whole thing. And it was wonderful. It was the second, I thought, comprehensive discography of an artist at that time, the first being *Hendersonia*, Walter C. Allen's book, which is huge. But it's a biodiscography of Fletcher Henderson that Walter C. Allen must have worked on forever. But it came out first, and then Benny's book came out with Ed's discography, which is just as comprehensive as anything Walter Allen did, maybe even more so in some ways. So when Benny came to the Institute, I even remember the first stupid question I asked him, I wish I could have taken that back, I said, "Well Benny," you know, trying to show I know a little something about jazz, I think I might have called him Mr. Carter even, I wasn't that comfortable with him yet. And I said you know, "Mr. Carter, could you sit down and tell me when the switchover from tuba and banjo, the switchover to bass and guitar. When did that happen exactly." Like there was an exact date that this happened, some magical date. And he looked at me like I had three heads. But he was such a nice guy. He didn't say what a stupid question. He just said, "Well," he said, "some arrangements called for tuba and banjo and some arrangements called for bass and guitar." And that pretty much was it.

MR: No kidding.

VP: There was no magical moment when this happened.

MR: Right.

VP: It just sort of evolved in time. And yeah I guess he was right.

MR: I know. It's like you want those things to have this — like when did music switch back to straight eighth notes. Well the day Chuck Berry — I mean you want this thing to be compartmentalized a little bit.

VP: You do. And the other interesting person I meet there was also Walter "Gil" Fuller.

MR: Gil Fuller.

VP: The arranger for Dizzy Gillespie. He took a liking to me. I don't know why. But he sort of took me under his wing, and he took me out to lunch many, many times. And basically he just poured out his life story to me. He felt like he'd been basically forgotten. He was

very proud of the one article that talked about him, Leonard Feather wrote the article in fact, about Gil Fuller. And he was very proud of that article, that at least somebody recognized his talents. And he was telling me all the things he did that he didn't get credit for, and of course I found out later that he also was a fantastic liar in a lot of ways, and exaggerator, and he exaggerated a lot of his accomplishments. And I won't say – I mean I don't know to what degree he did, but I have since found out that certain things he said he did he really didn't do, or he farmed out certain things to other arrangers, which they all did. Quincy Jones did it, they all kind of did it. He was very opinionated, there were certain people he just did not care for stylistically or whatever. He had a bug up his butt about Tadd Dameron for some reason. He really didn't think Tadd Dameron was all that great an arranger. And in fact he said to me, "If you listen to 'Hothouse,'" he says, "really listen to 'Hothouse,'" he says, "does that sound like Tadd Dameron would have done?" He said, "That sounds more to me like Charlie Parker might have wrote that and Dameron took credit for that" you know. Because he said, you know, "Dameron did things like 'Good Bait'" [scats] and then he would hum that to me, and then he would say, "now listen to 'Hot House' and tell me" [inaudible]. He loved Sy Oliver, he loved, again, a guy named Phil Moore, he was in love with him, he loved Quincy Jones, so Quincy Jones was okay. And he said he did some work for Benny Goodman — oh no, he said he was approached by Benny Goodman to do arrangements for the big band but he turned it down and gave it to Chico O'Farrill. Now I've heard Chico O'Farrill talk about that, and not once did he ever mention Gil Fuller giving him that job. So I kind of wonder what that was all about too. So yeah, but Gil was interesting. A lot of what he said was true. I mean a lot of things he said, I mean the whole thing with writing "Things to Come" and stuff like that. I mean, that was all his.

MR: I have a picture of an LP I had, "Last Train from Overbrook." I think it was James Moody.

VP: Yeah. Well he did the Moody arrangements for the Monterey Jazz Festival. Remember that? There were two albums that came out, because he was in charge of the Monterey Jazz Festival Orchestra for a while, and he did the Gillespie one, and then he did the Moody one. And those were his arrangements. I've yet to hear anybody dispute that, so I don't know. Maybe somebody will at some point. But he said he did those. And they're wonderful albums, both of them.

MR: Okay, you recall the *Down Beat* blindfold tests?

VP: Yes.

MR: Okay, so I'm going to give you one.

VP: Uh oh. Here's where my expertise goes down the toilet. Ed used to do this to me all the time. He'd go pick some record and it was like —

[audio interlude]

VP: It sounds like King Oliver's band.

MR: That's right.

VP: I can't name the title.

MR: "Sobbin' Blues"

VP: "Sobbin' Blues"? Yeah, yeah, okay.

MR: I love to picture — I wish I could have been a fly on the wall, I picture them in that studio playing in that megaphone and stuff.

VP: Oh, I would love to see that too. God. Because from what I heard and read, Armstrong was so powerful that they had to put him in the back of the room. Really. Oliver was in the front and he was back — it's the only way they could balance it. Really. It must have been wild.

MR: Yeah. All right. How about this one?

VP: Okay.

[audio interlude]

VP: Oh yeah, um, I don't know what take, but it's Jimmie Lunceford Orchestra, "Rhythm is our Business." But there are two takes. I can't tell you which one.

MR: Okay.

VP: Phil Schaap could tell you, but I can't.

MR: Phil Schaap could tell you.

VP: Yeah. Phil Schaap could tell you easily, but I can't. Oh I love that band. They were so clean. I mean it's just like wow.

MR: They really captured the string bass.

VP: Yes. Also, leaders were smart enough to push that bass up front. And Ellington does the same thing. You can always hear the bass on an Ellington recording, and the same thing with Lunceford. Fletcher, not so much. Fletcher wasn't really that hip with the recording thing. But Ellington was and so was Lunceford. And their recordings were wonderful. But I just always marvel at the clean, at how clean that band was. I mean —

MR: And apparently a lot of showmanship too.

VP: Yes, exactly, exactly, with the horns going up and tossing the hats up and stuff. That's great stuff man.

MR: Did you ever think you were born in the wrong era?

VP: Oh definitely. Oh damn was I born in the wrong era. Oh God was I born in the wrong era. I would have loved to have been a part of that. But like my father always said, he said, "Those weren't the good old days, those were the bad old days."

MR: I just was, that was sort of — I wondered, is there a good old days. But why would he have said that?

VP: Because of the racial stuff that was going on at the time. He was very aware of that, and while he never sat down and talked about any individual instances or episodes that he encountered, he never really talked about those days in a nostalgic sense in any way, shape or form. He always said, "It's better now. Things are better now." So I guess —

MR: And he would have said that about when, in the 60s?

VP: I would say as late as the 1970s. And one of the biggest regrets, other than the fact that I lost my father, he died in '72 I believe, was that he didn't live long enough to see Barack Obama become president of the United States. Because he always used to tell me, "There's no way in hell a black man is going to be president of the United States of America." He would not have believed it. He would never have believed it. And I would have loved for him to have seen that. It's like, "See, Pop, it did happen, Pop." That would have been great. Yeah, but that's it, you're right. Musically speaking that's where my heart really is. Now I love modern — I love everything bop and beyond, I'm a big Eric Dolphy fan for instance, I love Eric Dolphy. I love Coltrane. I just heard some Marty Ehrlich that I thought was fantastic. I mean so I like some out stuff, I dig Ornette, I dig Jim Lyons, but really my heart is in the old. I really love those old big bands and the swing guys. And that's my thing man. In fact the charts that you'd see in our big band that are from that time, I was partly responsible for getting.

MR: That's what I started to gather, and partly why I wanted to talk to you.

VP: And they rebelled. They go, "We can't keep playing this old stuff, we've got to play something more modern era." But see the reason why I brought the old stuff into the band was because I thought okay, our level of expertise, this is probably about all we can handle comfortably. Plus, if you play them right, they swing on their own man. I mean they sound good, even today they sound good, if you play it right and you've got the right feeling behind it and you hit the notes.

MR: Yeah. I have an internal debate sometimes when you're playing them and the tenor player stands up to solo and is playing like they're in the Tower of Power. And well —

VP: Yeah. I'm with you on that man. It's like, "Come on, man, come on."

MR: It's almost better that they don't know that it doesn't fit. Because if they know it doesn't fit then I think they're making a bad musical decision.

VP: But it's almost like if you take them to task then you also have to sort of take the drummer to task. Because chances are the drummers in those bands weren't keeping time on the hi hat, they were probably using the bass drum more. And it's a whole different feel actually. I don't think anybody today really knows how those drummers felt time. The bop thing has taken over. So everybody plays like a bop drummer now, even the swing guys. So that's just the way it is. Even the bass players are pushing more than they did in those days. I think it's like the same kind of feel. I should say they're more laid

back now. I think they pushed more in those days. They were more in your face. And of course you could hardly find any guitarists that wanted to just play rhythm. They just don't want to do that. In fact I had a guitar teacher, Remo Palmier, who said to me, "I don't do that four to the bar nonsense."

MR: Wow. He called it nonsense?

VP: Yeah. He didn't think that was cool. That's old fashioned. That's from another time. So when he would play in a big band he wouldn't do the four to the bar. He just did sort of like comping and that kind of thing, if he played with them at all.

MR: Bucky Pizzarelli said something that made a lot of sense to me. I asked him about, especially the early Basie band why they were so good. He said, "Well the drummer, and the rhythm section but especially the drummer didn't try to hit every kick the horns were playing."

VP: Yes.

MR: Because if you do then you don't have the back and forth. And after he said that I said well yes, of course.

VP: He's right.

MR: So if you get in front of a high school band and they have those drum parts that are so – there's way too much in them, and the poor drummers are trying to hit everything and you just take the music away.

VP: Yeah. That happened in a Benny Carter session actually with Kenny Washington playing drums. And he was trying to do that, get all the hits. And I think at some point Benny Carter got frustrated with him and said, "Don't bother with all that nonsense, just play the drums. Just play the drums. Just lay out a rhythm. That's all I need." It's interesting stuff.

MR: What's on your desert island playlist?

VP: Ah the old desert island. I should always think about that more, because, and of course it changes all the time I mean. Of course I'd have to have a Wes Montgomery record, and as to what my favorite one is it's kind of hard to say because I like all of them. Even the Creed Taylor stuff that he did later with the "California Dreamin'" and that stuff. Probably if I had to pick one I'd probably pick "The Incredible Jazz Guitar" Wes Montgomery. That's what everybody says is probably the best one. I'd have to have some Armstrong, I don't even know which album for that. I guess I would just pick a 78 maybe and one of my favorites of his was — well there are two — his big band version of "Struttin' with Some Barbeque," it's fantastic, the Decca version of that, it's oh my God. And also "Wolverine Blues" that he does later with Sid Catlett playing drums behind him man. That's a kick-ass record. So both of them, I would take one or the other. I had another one just on the tip of my tongue. Oh, we listened to it last night, I would take Benny Carter's "Further Definitions" album with me. That is a great record. It's only

about 35 minutes long but it's great. I mean there's not a track on there where you're waiting for it to get over to get to the next track. Every track is perfect. I just love that record. So I guess those are enough.

MR: Okay.

VP: Maybe I'll take a Bix Beiderbecke record also.

MR: All right.

VP: I love Bix. And I guess I would take, oh what's the one with Bix and his gang. Oh come on Vinny I know it. It's not "Thou Swell" but it's one of the Bix and his gang ones. I can't think of the name now. But I got flak for liking Bix actually.

MR: From whom?

VP: From people who go like, "What's so great about Bix?" I mean a lot of modern trumpeters listen to him and they don't see what the big deal is. And I guess because they've heard so many Bix imitators now that they don't realize that he was the source. It starts with him. Really. They're all imitating him basically. So it's like you've heard so many of the imitators you can't appreciate the real thing when you hear it.

MR: Did you ever meet Randy Sandke?

VP: I love Randy Sandke.

MR: He named his kid Bix.

VP: Yes, yes. He brought him to the Institute just recently. Yeah cool Bix. Yeah He's wild. And there is a case of a guy who, and this is where I think a lot of musicians should sort of follow his lead. I mean he can play the old stuff. But have you heard some of his more out stuff?

MR: Yeah. His writing. Yeah. He did the thing for old time string instruments.

VP: Yeah. He can do the whole gamut. He's a hell of a musician, definitely is.

MR: Are there any jazz myths that bug you.

VP: Yeah. I'll tell you one right away – that the black musicians are better than the white musicians. I've heard that forever. We had a guy that worked at the Institute, John Clement, British, he would say English, he didn't like the idea I think, to be part of the British Empire. He thought English. "See I'm English" he'd always say. He always felt that black musicians were superior to white musicians. And I've heard that nonsense for I don't know how long. And I know the famous story about Roy saying he could tell a white, and he couldn't. When they actually did it he couldn't do it. And I'm sorry man but you can not tell me that Bunny Berrigan ain't bad. Bunny Berrigan is bad. All right? But Benny Goodman could play. Artie Show can play. All these cats — Pee Wee Russell can play. I'm sorry. You can't tell me black musicians are superior when you've got cats like that. And that goes true for today. I mean to me the whole, now I'm one of those who do feel that jazz is a black music. I mean I've heard that controversy also, that it's not.

But no, I think it is, based primarily on the fact that, you know if you look at its main movers and shakers, they all seem to be African American and, you know, there are wonderful players, there are groups that can play the music, and that's wonderful. It's no different than black musicians playing Bach or Mozart. I mean that's why not? I mean they can do it, sure. But they're not trying to claim the music. I never heard a black person say, you know, Bach was black or Mozart was black. Maybe somebody has but I never heard it. So yeah, that's a myth I really wish would just die I mean and never come back up again. Because it's nonsense. Really.

MR: Frank Foster said the coolest, succinct — he said, jazz is the experience — came out of the experience of a black musician in America and no one's ever going to tell me different. But now our culture is so — he had a really good way of saying it. I think there's some things that we wish happened differently. For instance, tomorrow is the hundredth anniversary of the Original Dixieland Jass Band.

VP: Yes it is.

MR: It would have been nice if King Oliver —

VP: Or Freddie Keppard.

MR: Could have had that historical distinction.

VP: Yeah. It would have been nice. And this controversy too, I've heard people say, "Wasn't James Reese Europe the first person to put jazz on record?" I had a guy pigeonhole me. We were on some panel together and he got me in a corner and he was pushing hard. And he said, "Come on you have to agree with me that James Reese Europe was the first —" I just said, "Listen man, I know what you're trying to do. I know you don't like the fact that the ODJB, a white group, was the first." This happened to be a black Muslim by the way. And so he was pushing that whole black thing. And I was like, "I'm sorry man, I just can't go with it." I mean what Europe was playing was peppy and syncopated, but it wasn't jazz in any shape or form. It wasn't jazz. And you can't say that, it's just not true. And even though it was 1914, you can't say it was the first jazz. So he didn't go with it. He still thought I was wrong. But you're right. I might agree with you. I wish it had been a little different. Because really, when you hear the ODJB records, I don't want to say they're corny but —

MR: They're corny. Well you've got to think of the time it was but we know now it wasn't the real thing that could have been captured.

VP: It's close. Close enough for jazz.

MR: Close enough for jazz. Oh, I love talking to you. I'm not sure I can phrase this question, to sort of wrap up. You know we've been talking about the past and what's your take on jazz in America now, considering record sales and jazz education and jazz as an art form.

VP: It's all over the place right now. You know it's interesting that you ask me the question because one of the thing that Ed and I — Ed Berger — I keep bringing his name up and I guess it's because his death is still so fresh in my head. But he used to talk about the fact that we have this chancellor in Newark now, I used to say she's new but she's been here for a couple of years ago so she's not that new anymore. And she's been trying to use the Institute of Jazz Studies as a sort of a way to, I don't know, to like connect with some of the other cultural organizations in Newark. So we've been partnering with NJPAC for some things. We we've always kind of did that but now it's more so that that's happening, in their jazz program. And also the Newark Museum and the Library and other groups similar. And so she sees jazz as kind of a way to bring more notoriety to the Institute, and to Rutgers University, and also as a fundraising mechanism, which is interesting because jazz sales and the popularity of jazz, also WGBO is another institution in Newark that we're trying to kind of partner more with. And we always have sort of partnered with them — they used to have a show called Jazz From the Archives for years, before they canceled us. So really I see jazz as doing a lot of different things. I mean the fear that it's going to become a museum music, it's still very much there. Because we were talking last night about Fats Navarro and Clifford Brown and Kenny Dorham and stuff like that. And we looked at each other and said we sat around, a bunch of old farts sitting around talking about the good old days. Like the kids today don't know who these people are today. I mean what are we doing here you know. Is this what jazz is now? Just a bunch of old recordings? So there's that fear. But, you know, I also Thursday, last Thursday before coming down here Valery Ponomarev, the Russian trumpeter. I always mess up his last name. He had a group of kids NJPAC has something called Jazz for Teens.

MR: Can you tell me what MJPAC is?

VP: Oh, New Jersery Performing Arts.

MR: Oh, NJPAC.

VP: They have a thing called jazz for teens. And they have these kids come in, and he is instructing them how to play jazz. And man these kids, I mean they couldn't have been any more than maybe 14, 15. And the trumpeter was cool. He was the leader, because he had on the nice suit and the nice shiny shoes and the little handkerchief in his pocket and had his hair all slicked back, had his horn. And he was leading them man. I mean and they're playing "Night in Tunisia," the drummer's doing the thing, and Valery is sitting next to me and he's just laughing his butt off. "Listen to that, the phrase, they're answering each other." The pianist is answering the guy that was playing the sax. And you see that and you say, "Okay. There's a future. That's the future. These kids know man." They've obviously been listening and they've been picking it up, and people like

Valery is hipping them and so I think jazz is going to be okay. It's never going to be popular like it was in the 30s and 40s. You're never going to see that again. That's gone, that's done. But it's going to be there. If you want to see it, and you know where to find it, you will find it, because it will be there. And we have all these programs still, you have all these colleges with jazz happening in them. You have master's degrees in jazz history now so that those people will be out there. So I think it's in good hands. It just isn't going to be like it was in the old days. I also think that you can always find the kind of jazz you're really interested in. Someone's playing it somewhere. If you like Dixieland you can find it. There's somebody somewhere doing it. Somebody just told me that there seems to be this now growth in swing bands, like small swing bands, people playing that type of music now more than they did before. And maybe that's happening. That's great. I think the jazz parties are dying though. I don't think you'll have too many more of those anymore.

MR: Yeah. They'll probably go out.

VP: Yeah.

MR: The audience is not sort of fulfilling.

VP: That's a shame. And I don't know about the jazz cruises. I don't know if they're still happening or not. I suppose once in a while.

MR: Well I just talked to someone who went on an incredible jazz cruise. Like everybody was there.

VP: Um hm. Well maybe that's another way of getting out there. And hopefully what I hope will happen too is you know Carol Bash's film, "The Lady Who Swings the Band" on Mary Lou Williams just came out, and of course it's been a while since Ken Burns' film on jazz came out. I think it's time for another film like that, another documentary like that. And some gentleman came to me from some neat company in Europe and they did ask me questions for a film that they're doing on jazz, which I hope will come out soon. So somebody else is doing something besides Ken Burns. And I hope there'll be more projects like Carol Bash's, "The Lady Who Swings the Band" and get that stuff out on television and so on. Like somebody once said, you know, you always hear jazz is dead, every ten years or something, whatever.

MR: You know what I think about that, I think they need something to write about. When's the last time anybody wrote jazz is dead? Okay, that was five years ago, it's time to do it again.

VP: Yeah exactly. I agree. But it's not dead. It's not dead. It's alive. It may be on life support but it's still there. It's in good hands. And hopefully places like ours and yours, who have these institutes, will keep things going. You know, you've got a great web site, you've

got that YouTube channel which I've got to talk to you about actually, and YouTube, everything's on YouTube now. It's like —

MR: How can it go away?

VP: Exactly. Exactly. So I think it's in good hands. I think it's in really good hands. I'm very optimistic.

MR: And on that upbeat, thank you very much, it's been a real pleasure.

VP: Thanks, Monk. It was a pleasure talking to you.